

From Batauli to Butwal:

A Historical and Socio-Cultural Study of Pari Butwal's Heritage and Its Evolution into a Modern Economic Hub

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Abstract

This study examines the historical, cultural, and socio-economic dimensions of Pari Butwal, the origin of modern Butwal City in Lumbini Province, Nepal. Once a thriving trade hub known as Batauli Bazar under the Palpa Kingdom, Pari Butwal holds significant historical importance, exemplified by the Jitgadhi Fort, where Nepali forces achieved a rare victory against the East India Company during the Anglo-Nepalese War, and the Manimukunda Sen Park, a 16th-century royal garden turned public heritage site. The research explores the architectural ingenuity of ancient houses, the economic legacy of Purano Bazar, and the enduring religious harmony among diverse communities in Pari Butwal. In contrast, it analyzes the rapid urbanization and economic dominance of Butwal City (Khasauli), highlighting disparities in development between the two regions despite their shared roots. Through fieldwork, interviews, and historical analysis, this study aims to preserve the cultural legacy of Pari Butwal while addressing its developmental challenges in the face of modern Butwal's growth. It underscores the need for balanced progress to revive Pari Butwal's historical charm and integrate it into Nepal's broader narrative of resilience and unity.

Introduction

Butwal is a city in Rupandehi district, situated within Lumbini Province, one of the seven federal provinces of Nepal. The name Butwal traces its origin to Batauli Bazar, which was once part of the Chaubise Rajya, a confederation of twenty-four kingdoms spanning the Gandaki region and the Terai belt during the rule of the Thakuri kings. At that time, the settlement was also referred to as Batauli Bazar. The kingdom occupied the geographic intersection of the Himalayas and the Indian Subcontinent, and Butwal, as part of the Palpa Kingdom, was one of the most significant political and commercial entities of its era. Batauli Bazar functioned consistently as a center of both

education and trade. Following the unification campaign initiated by King Prithivi Narayan Shah, the Chaubise Rajya, along with all its constituent kingdoms, was incorporated into the unified nation of Nepal. In 2071 B.S., Batauli Bazar was upgraded from Khasauli Municipality to Butwal Sub-Metropolitan City, and it presently serves as a principal economic hub of Lumbini Province, with tourist destinations that include Nuwakot, Butwal Hill Park, Manimukunda Sen Park, and Jitgadhi Fort.

In the lap of Nuwakot Hill, beside the bank of the Tinau River, lies a small town named Pari Butwal, which is also recognized as the central origin of Butwal Sub-Metropolitan City. Despite its modest size, Pari Butwal encompasses sites of considerable historical importance and has played a vital role in the economic development of modern Butwal (Khasauli). It is the location where one of the significant battles of the Anglo-Nepalese War, also known as the Gorkha War, was fought. The Anglo-Nepalese War was a conflict between the Nepali Army, referred to as the Gorkhali Sena, and the East India Company, a contingent of the Royal British monarchy. Nepal ultimately ceded approximately one-third of its territory through the Sugauli Treaty of 1816 A.D. However, at the Jitgadhi Fort located within Pari Butwal, the Gorkhali forces led by Colonel Ujir Singh Thapa succeeded in defeating the British, marking one of the rare military victories for Nepal during the course of the war.

Pari Butwal also contains the historically significant Manimukunda Sen Park, locally referred to as Phulbari. This park was originally the private garden of King Manimukunda Sen of the Palpa Kingdom and is believed to have been constructed in the 16th century. Following Nepal's unification, the garden fell into disuse and deteriorated. It was later revived as a public heritage site, and in 2074 B.S., a statue of King Manimukunda Sen was installed within the park by Khem Prashad Luitel, the Chairman of the Manimukunda Sen Park Committee. The park is currently recognized for its lush greenery, well-maintained gardens, peaceful ambience, scenic views of Butwal City from the Chure Hills, and a small zoo housing animals such as python, leopard, deer, ostrich, and nilgai.

Pari Butwal, as the genesis of Butwal City, also retains ancient residential structures estimated to be over 350 years old. These houses were constructed entirely from locally available materials, including Sal ko Kaath (*Shorea Robusta* timber), Rato Mato (red clay), and stone. They were designed to withstand natural disasters such as earthquakes, though the 2072 B.S. earthquake caused damage to several of these structures. Residents continue to value these houses for their natural insulation properties: they remain cool in summer and warm in winter. Batauli Bazar, now commonly referred to as Purano Bazar, has historically served as the primary trade center for communities in the Terai and hilly regions, functioning through both the barter and monetary systems. However, most businesses have since relocated to Khasauli, with a notable exception being the 141-year-old Bajre ko Jalebi Pasal, which continues to operate in the same location.

The social fabric of Pari Butwal is characterized by a remarkable degree of religious coexistence. Communities of Hindu and Muslim backgrounds, among others, live in close

proximity and share a common way of life. A Masjid and a Temple stand facing each other in the locality, symbolizing interfaith unity. This Masjid, approximately 112 years old, is among the oldest in Butwal. Historically, religious tensions were more prevalent, but increased education and mutual respect over time have contributed to a more harmonious community.

Pari Butwal (Batauli) and Butwal City (Khasauli) are separated by the Tinau River, with Batauli on the left bank and Khasauli on the right. A clear developmental disparity exists between the two sides, attributable to Khasauli's superior connectivity to nearby towns such as Tansen, Kapilvastu, and Lumbini, and its function as a gateway to cities including Sunawal, Pokhara, and Bhaktapur, as well as the land route to India. Pari Butwal, constrained by its surrounding hills and river and lacking access to major economic routes, has faced significant infrastructural limitations. Seasonal flooding, inadequate transportation infrastructure, educational deficits relative to Khasauli, and the presence of Sukumbasi (slum) settlements compound its developmental challenges.

Research Objectives

This study was conducted with the following objectives: to highlight the historical importance of Jitgadhi Fort; to examine the history of Manimukunda Sen Park; to analyze the advantages and disadvantages of residing in the ancient houses of Pari Butwal; to document the historical significance of Purano Bazar; to understand the shared mode of life among people of different religions living in Pari Butwal; and to evaluate the developmental differences between the historic Batauli and present-day Butwal City.

Jitgadhi Fort

Among the many battles fought on Nepali soil, the engagement at Jitgadhi Fort stands as one of the most historically remarkable. Situated on the bank of the Tinau River in Pari Butwal, Jitgadhi Fort is the site where Nepal's Gorkhali Sena achieved a decisive victory against the East India Company, a contingent of the Royal British monarchy, during the Anglo-Nepalese War. The fort is also historically referred to as Butwal Gadhi. The etymology of the name Jitgadhi is itself a record of this triumph: Jit denotes victory, and Gadhi denotes fort.

During the Anglo-Nepalese War, military operations by the East India Company were conducted across five to seven locations in Nepal between 1814 and 1816 B.S. However, the only location where the Gorkhali Sena prevailed was Jitgadhi Fort, which accordingly received its name. The fort also contained a tunnel connecting it to Nuwakot, which served as an escape route for soldiers during wartime. This tunnel has since been demolished due to safety concerns.



Figure 1. Commemorative bronze plaque installed at Jitgadhi Fort detailing the historic victory of the Gorkhali Sena against the East India Company. The inscription records the contributions of Colonel Ujir Singh Thapa and the brave warriors of the Anglo-Nepalese War. The national flag and life-size statue of Ujir Singh Thapa, inaugurated by former Prime Minister KP Sharma Oli in 2075 B.S., were established in their honor.

The leader of the Gorkhali Sena in this engagement was Colonel Ujir Singh Thapa, a distinguished military commander and the grandson of Amar Singh Thapa, widely known as the Living Lion of Nepal. Amar Singh Thapa had proclaimed, "I am a cub of a tiger; do not mistake me for a carcass-eating dog." This declaration was subsequently vindicated by his grandson, whose military conduct at Jitgadhi reflected the same spirit of resolute defiance. Ujir Singh Thapa, also known as Wazir Shima Thapa, also served as the Governor of the Palpa Kingdom. He was born in Chaitra of 1852 B.S. and died on 20th Mangsir 1881 B.S., having lived for only twenty-nine years, yet serving his nation until his final days.

In order to deepen the study's understanding of Jitgadhi Fort, the researchers conducted an interview with Mr. Gurung, the current caretaker of the fort. He stated: "209 years ago, an army led by Colonel Ujir Singh Thapa defeated the East India Company led by Major General Wood. The war between Nepal and the East India Company took place in five to seven locations, but the only place where the Nepalese Army overpowered the British was Jitgadhi Fort, and that is why it was named Jitgadhi."

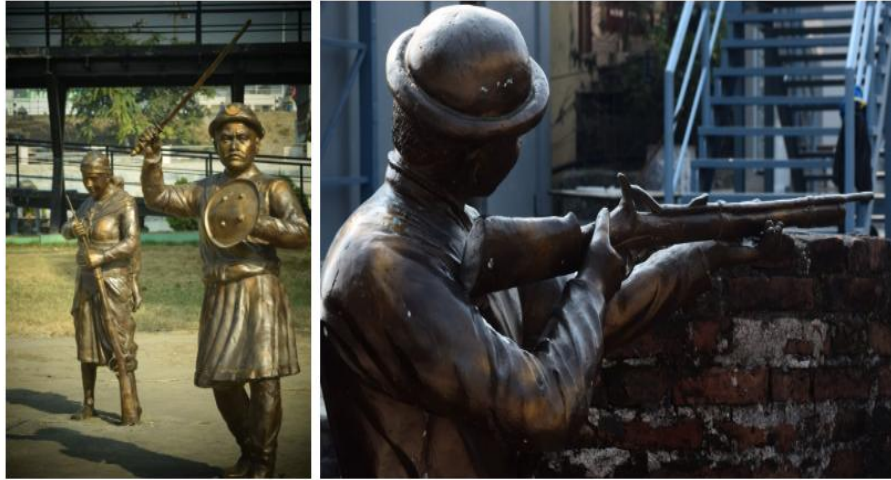


Figure 2. Bronze sculptures installed at Jitgadhi Fort depicting Gorkhali soldiers and local Nepalese combatants during the Anglo-Nepalese War. These figures represent the bravery of the Gorkha forces, who engaged the technologically superior British army using traditional weapons such as Khukuri, Hasiya, and Bancharo.

The sculptures at Jitgadhi Fort serve as a visual record of the sacrifices made by the Gorkhali soldiers and the local civilian population, including women and children who participated in the resistance. Marshal Sam Manekshaw's oft-cited remark that "if a man says he is not afraid of dying, he is either lying or he is a Gorkha" finds its material expression in these figures. The Nepali forces, armed with only domestic implements, succeeded in repelling an imperial military that possessed significant technological and logistical advantages. The fort's position along the bank of the Tinau River further aided the defensive strategy of the Gorkhali forces.

Every year on the 7th of Baishakh, the victory at Jitgadhi is commemorated as Jitgadhi Bijaya Diwas. The celebration involves community rallies, Sarai dance performances, and a march-past conducted by retired military personnel in tribute to those who gave their lives in the war.



(A)



(B)

Figure 3. (A) The 42-feet-tall national flag of Nepal erected at Jitgadhi Fort, flying continuously for 24 hours as established by Er. Dharmaraj Dhakal, in honor of the soldiers who sacrificed their lives in the Anglo-Nepalese War. (B) Shree Ujir Singh Secondary School, established in the memory and honor of Colonel Ujir Singh Thapa.

Mr. Gurung further noted that the flag at Jitgadhi "does not fly because the wind moves it; it flies with the last breath of each soldier who died protecting it." Rabindra Gopal Kalali, a local resident, expressed hope that the fort, which had long suffered from neglect and inadequate preservation, would gain the recognition it deserves following the installation of Ujir Singh Thapa's life-size statue and the national flag. Former Deputy Mayor and historian Bimal Bahadur Shakya has stated that Jitgadhi is being developed as "the symbol of nationality and Butwal's historic landmark and identity."

The Jitgadhi Fort represents an irreplaceable component of Nepal's national heritage. Preservation efforts must be sustained and strengthened, particularly given the fort's proximity to the Tinau River, which renders it vulnerable to damage from seasonal flooding and natural disasters. While the government has taken notable steps through the installation of the statue and the national flag, the fort remains relatively unknown to a significant portion of the Nepali population. Both institutional governing bodies and the broader public carry a responsibility to promote awareness of Jitgadhi's historical significance.

Manimukunda Sen Park (Phulbari)

Situated on the western periphery of Butwal City, in the lap of the Chure Hills, Manimukunda Sen Park, locally known as Phulbari, is among the most historically and ecologically significant public spaces in Pari Butwal. The park covers an area of approximately 25 Bighas of land and commands a panoramic view of Butwal City and the surrounding plains. Its history

predates the modern city entirely: the park was originally constructed in the 16th century as the summer retreat and winter palace of King Manimukunda Sen of the Sen Dynasty, the ruling family of the Palpa Kingdom.

The park currently encompasses the ruins of King Sen's palace, a Ramapithecus garden commemorating early hominid traces found near the Tinau River, the Vishnupaduka, a statue of Lord Buddha, a Martyrs' monument, a waterfall and pond, the Madan-Ashrit, the Manmohan Garden, monasteries, temples, a view tower, a flower garden, a Republic Pillar, a Zodiac section, and a small zoo housing animals including leopard, ostrich, monkey, and deer. This combination of ecological, archaeological, and religious features renders Phulbari a multifaceted heritage site. It is a popular picnic destination for schools from Butwal and surrounding areas and draws visitors from as far as Tansen, Kapilvastu, and across the border in Uttar Pradesh, India. The park is most frequented during the months of November and December, when the weather is most conducive to travel.



Figure 4. Life-size equestrian statue of King Manimukunda Sen installed within Manimukunda Sen Park (Phulbari). The statue was unveiled on 2074-02-16 B.S. by Mr. Khem Prashad Luitel, Chairman of the Manimukunda Sen Park Committee, in recognition of King Sen's historical legacy and his foundational role in establishing the garden.

The park's transition from a royal garden to a public heritage site was neither immediate nor uncontested. To gather historical perspective, the researchers interviewed Mr. Bharat Shakya, a longtime local resident with detailed knowledge of the park's history. He recounted that prior to 2037 B.S., the park had fallen into severe neglect under the governing bodies of the time, to the extent that the once-beautiful garden of King Sen was converted into a dumping site for Butwal Municipality. This action prompted strong disapproval among local residents.

A significant turning point occurred in 2037 B.S., when Butwal Nagar Panchayat, under the leadership of Munnilal Shakya, renamed the park Aishwarya Park in honor of Queen Aishwarya, a move deliberately intended to attract national attention. While this act resulted in partial improvements to the site, a comprehensive renovation did not follow until 2049 B.S., when,

following the establishment of a multiparty democratic system in Nepal, funding was allocated for the park's full restoration. Mr. Shakya noted that the park reaches its peak visitors during the marriage season in the month of Mangsir, with many families selecting the park as a wedding venue due to its religious and scenic value.

Mr. Shakya also drew attention to the paleontological significance of the Ramapithecus garden within Phulbari. He stated that traces of Ramapithecus, an early hominid species, were historically found near the bank of the Tinau River, and that monuments representing this species have been installed in the park to inform visitors of the region's deep prehistoric heritage. "This park has now evolved into Lumbini Province's premier tourist destination," he observed, "with a significant number of Indian students, particularly from Uttar Pradesh, visiting regularly."

The trajectory of Manimukunda Sen Park illustrates a broader pattern observable throughout Pari Butwal: the tension between historical inheritance and contemporary institutional neglect. The park endures as a site of cultural, ecological, and recreational value, but its continued development requires sustained attention from the relevant authorities and a recognition of its potential as both a heritage site and a driver of local tourism.

Purano Bazar

The commercial foundation of what has become modern Butwal City was laid not in Khasauli, but in Batauli. The market known today as Purano Bazar was, for a significant portion of its history, the primary trade center for communities across the Terai belt and the hilly regions of Nepal, including the Palpa Kingdom. The name Batauli Bazar itself reflects the market's centrality to the identity of the settlement.

During the height of its activity, goods were transported from India to Batauli via Bel-Gadi (bullock cart), and the market served as the principal source of domestic supplies for people in the Terai and hilly regions. Communities from the hills traveled for days, even weeks, to reach Batauli Bazar, where they exchanged local produce such as ghee, potatoes, maize, barley, and apples for goods including salt (Nun), sugar (Chini), spices, tea, and Sidhra Macha (dried anchovies). Similarly, people from Himalayan regions exchanged barley, wheat, apples, and potatoes for commodities available at the bazar. This dual trade network operated through both the barter system and the monetary system, making Purano Bazar one of the few markets in Nepal to have functioned across both economic modes.

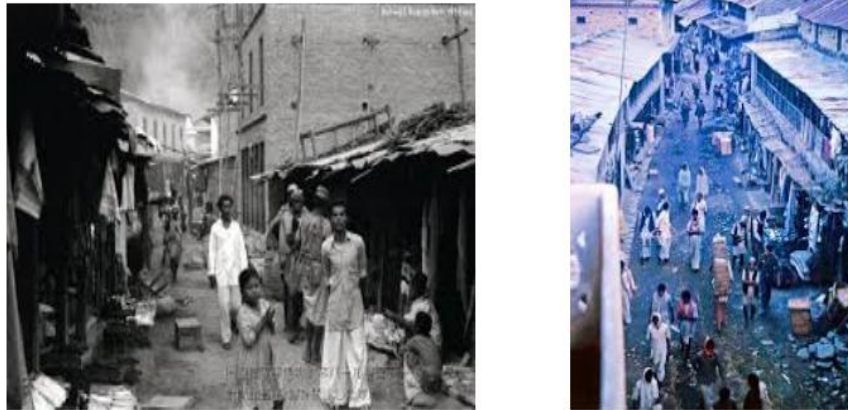


Figure 5. Archival photographs of Purano Bazar documenting its historical significance as a major trade center in Batauli. The images depict the densely populated lanes and vibrant commercial activity that characterized the bazar during its peak, when it served as the primary marketplace for communities from both the Terai belt and the hilly regions of Nepal.

The fieldwork for this study revealed that the market, which once operated at such density that finding standing space was reportedly difficult, has undergone a substantial decline. Almost all of the businesses that originated in Batauli Bazar have since relocated to Khasauli in pursuit of better commercial opportunities and greater connectivity. Many of those enterprises, which began as small huts in Purano Bazar, have grown into multi-story commercial establishments, with their owners now recognized as prominent business figures in Butwal. The migration of these businesses represents a significant loss to the economic and cultural identity of Batauli.

The most enduring example of commercial continuity in Purano Bazar is the establishment locally known as Baje ko Jalebi Pasal, a sweet shop that has been operating in the same location for over 141 years. The founder began his enterprise in a small hut, serving Jalebi on sal ko paat (leaf plates) at a price of 35 paisa per serving. The business has since been continued by his son and grandchildren, who maintain the original recipe and flavor. The physical infrastructure of the shop has been modernized, but the culinary tradition remains intact.



Figure 6. Photographic documentation of Baje ko Jalebi Pasal, the oldest continuously operating shop in Purano Bazar, in business for over 141 years. The images include a framed photograph of the founder at work and an archival photograph depicting the shop in its earlier incarnation, reflecting the generational continuity of this establishment.

The son of the founder, who has personally managed the business for sixty-eight years, shared several accounts of daily life in the Batauli of his youth. He recalled his father selling twelve Sel roti for one Rupee, and described the circumstances under which he himself was compelled to abandon his studies in grade eight following the death of his mother, assuming full responsibility for the family business. He also recounted that there were no gas stoves at the time, requiring residents to gather firewood from surrounding jungles for cooking. He observed that the old municipality office of Batauli has since been converted into a museum, and described a time when the arrival of a single television in a neighbor's home drew the entire community together to witness it, reflecting the modest economic conditions that prevailed even within what was then a functioning trade center.

The history of Purano Bazar underscores a critical developmental dynamic in Pari Butwal. The commercial infrastructure that gave rise to modern Butwal was seeded in Batauli, yet the economic benefits of that foundation have been largely transferred to Khasauli. The continued operation of Baje ko Jalebi Pasal stands as evidence that commercial viability in Batauli is not inherently impossible. The example of its 141-year longevity presents a compelling case for other businessmen whose enterprises originated in Batauli to reconsider their current locations and contribute to the revitalization of the market from which their commercial trajectories first emerged.

Purano Ghar: Ancient Houses of Pari Butwal

Among the most distinctive physical features of Pari Butwal is the presence of ancient residential structures that remain standing within the locality, some of which are estimated to be over 350 years in age. These houses, constructed entirely through manual labor and without the use of modern technology, represent a significant example of traditional Nepali architecture and

building practice. Their construction materials were entirely locally sourced: Sal ko Kaath (Shorea Robusta timber), Rato Mato (red clay), stone, and brick. External surfaces were finished with limestone (Chuna) and red ochre (Geru). The structures consist of a minimum of two and a maximum of three storeys, connected by wooden staircases, and incorporate an Aati, a storage room located at the top of the building, which served both practical and spatial functions.

The architectural design of these houses reflects a sophisticated understanding of passive thermal regulation. Walls constructed to a thickness of approximately 18 inches provide natural insulation, maintaining warmth during winter and coolness during summer without any mechanical systems. Ishowrlal Joshi, a local resident whose house is approximately 200 years old, confirmed this in an interview: "The primary advantage of the house is that throughout winter it remains warm and during summer it remains chilly. This is also a major reason why we still prefer this ancient house, even though we have a modern pakki ghar." The windows and doors of these structures are ornamented with carved wooden sculptures of deities, reflecting the religious significance attributed to the home as a protected space.



Figure 7. Current condition of the ancient houses of Pari Butwal. The photographs document the deteriorating state of these structures, resulting from insufficient maintenance, exposure to adverse weather conditions, and abandonment. The primary construction materials, including Sal ko Kaath (timber), stone, and Rato Mato (red clay), remain visible. External surfaces were traditionally painted using limestone (Chuna) and red ochre (Geru).

Despite their design durability, several of these houses suffered damage during the earthquake of 12th Baisakh, 2072 B.S. (25th April, 2015). Importantly, the structures that had been properly maintained were better able to withstand the seismic event, while those in a state of neglect were more severely affected or entirely destroyed. This pattern indicates that the structural integrity of these houses is contingent not on their inherent design weaknesses, but on the regularity and quality of their upkeep. Maintenance involves annual application of a mud plaster mixture composed of Rato Mato, water, and cow dung (Gobbar), typically carried out during festival seasons such as Dashain and Tihar.

Manish Shrestha, a local resident, shared during fieldwork that his house has stood for six generations, giving it an approximate age of 400 years. He and his family continue to reside in the structure and operate a small family printing business from within it. During a tour of the property, minor crack damage attributable to the 2015 earthquake was visible, though he assessed it as structurally repairable. Mr. Joshi also identified the primary drawbacks of these houses: the risk of roofing materials being dislodged during storms, the regular requirement for replastering, and the historical placement of restrooms at a distance from the main structure, which created sanitation challenges.

At present, most of the ancient houses in Pari Butwal are either lightly inhabited or have been abandoned by their owners, accelerating their deterioration. The researchers observe that these structures constitute a form of cultural and architectural heritage that, if left unmanaged, will be irreversibly lost. Their preservation is achievable through several mechanisms: the handover of unoccupied structures to the government for institutional maintenance, the introduction of homestay tourism initiatives that provide economic incentive for upkeep, and the construction of new buildings using traditional materials and design principles reinforced by modern engineering techniques. These ancient houses are not only aesthetic artifacts; they are material evidence of pre-industrial building knowledge and a resource for understanding the domestic, religious, and social life of Pari Butwal across multiple centuries.

Brotherhood: Interfaith Coexistence in Pari Butwal

The social cohesion of Pari Butwal constitutes one of its most significant and, at the same time, most difficult-to-quantify attributes. The original inhabitants of Pari Butwal were the Newari Samudaya (Newar community). Over successive generations and through patterns of internal migration, people from Muslim, Brahmin, Chhetri, Madhesi, and other communities settled in Batauli, creating a diverse and layered social fabric. Despite differences in caste, religious practice, and cultural tradition, the residents of Pari Butwal have developed and maintained a shared mode of life that encompasses collective participation in festivals, rituals, moments of joy, and shared hardship.

During the fieldwork conducted for this study, the researchers observed children of visibly different religious backgrounds playing together in the lanes of Batauli, while their parents engaged in casual conversation nearby. A Temple and a Mosque stand in direct visual proximity to each other within the locality, and the sounds of the temple bell and the Adhan (the Islamic call to prayer) have long coexisted in the neighborhood. What initially appeared as a potentially contentious proximity was encountered in practice as a source of community identity and pride.

Birendra Mani Tuladhar, a Newari resident, provided detailed insight into how the Newar community celebrates Mha Puja, the Newar New Year. He described a process beginning with home-based Mandap construction and ritual performance, followed by a community procession

accompanied by cries of *Nhu Daya Bhintuna* (Welcome, New Year). During *Yomari Punhi*, a stall distributing *Yomari*, a traditional Newari sweet, is established in the locality and the sweet is shared with all community members irrespective of religious affiliation. Mr. Tuladhar stated that this practice serves to strengthen social bonds across communities while simultaneously preserving Newari cultural heritage. By coincidence, one day of the research period fell on the occasion of *Yomari* distribution, which the researchers were able to directly witness and participate in.

From the Newar community's neighborhood, the researchers proceeded to the Masjid, guided by Mr. Tuladhar, who facilitated the introduction. The Masjid is approximately 111 years old and was originally constructed by a group of Pahadi Muslims. An official committee was formed in 2049 B.S. as the Muslim population in Batauli increased, and the Masjid was formally registered with the Government of Nepal in 2052 B.S. as the only Masjid of Batauli. Given its size and regional significance, people from Sainamaina, Tilottama, Bhairawa, and Kapilvastu visit the Masjid during major festivals. The institution also operates a hostel providing shelter and education to twelve to fifteen orphan children.

An interview was conducted with Mr. Hajir Rahamad Khan Miya, the current Chairman of the Masjid. Before commencing the interview, Mr. Khan removed a *Dhaka topi* (the national headgear of Nepal) from his pocket and placed it on his head, an act that conveyed his sense of shared national identity in a manner that required no verbal articulation. He noted that the orphans housed and educated within the Masjid's hostel facility are drawn from multiple religious backgrounds, including Hindu, Buddhist, and Muslim families. He explained the rationale: "Since we believe that all humans are creatures created by God, all are equal, and that is the reason we do not believe in religious differences and promote brotherhood."

Mr. Khan further elaborated on the practice of interfaith participation in festivals. He noted that Muslim families in Batauli visit their Hindu neighbors during *Dashain*, *Tihar*, and *Teej*, and that Hindu families reciprocate during *Eid* and *Ramadan*. He offered a remark that encapsulated the depth of this cultural integration: "There is *Ram* in *Ramadan*, and *Ali* in *Dipawali*." This observation, emerging not from abstract principle but from lived community experience, suggests that religious identity in *Pari Butwal* has been shaped by proximity, mutual respect, and longstanding coexistence rather than by enforced assimilation or superficial tolerance.

The interfaith coexistence observed in *Pari Butwal* offers a model of community organization that stands in contrast to the religious tensions that characterize many other communities in South Asia and globally. It merits documentation, analysis, and recognition, both as an aspect of *Pari Butwal*'s cultural heritage and as an example of the social conditions that are possible when diverse communities share space, history, and daily life over extended periods.

Batauli and Butwal City: A Comparative Analysis

Butwal City, centered on Khasauli, is among the most significant urban centers in Lumbini Province, functioning as a major economic, educational, and healthcare hub for the broader region. According to the 2021 census, Butwal has a population of 195,054 and covers an area of 101.61 square kilometers. Geographically, it occupies the intersection of two major national highways, the Mahendra Highway and the Siddhartha Highway, making it a critical node connecting the Terai plains to the hill towns of Palpa and to the Indian border at Sunauli. This infrastructural positioning has been central to Butwal's commercial and demographic growth over the past several decades. The city's economy has transitioned from an agricultural base to a diversified urban economy comprising commercial establishments, financial institutions, educational institutions, and healthcare facilities.

Butwal City has two principal constituent towns: Khasauli and Batauli, separated by the Tinau River and connected by the Tinau Bridge. Though both towns share a common historical origin, their trajectories of development have diverged markedly. Pari Butwal, or Batauli, occupies the left bank of the Tinau and represents the older and original settlement of Butwal City. Khasauli, on the right bank, has become the dominant commercial and residential center of the two.

A comparative analysis of the two towns reveals a consistent pattern: Khasauli leads Batauli across virtually every developmental indicator at the present time, including commercial activity, population density, educational infrastructure, healthcare access, and transportation connectivity. However, this represents a reversal of historical conditions. Batauli was the pioneer in each of these domains. The earliest school in Butwal City was located in Batauli. Purano Bazar in Batauli preceded and contributed to the commercial development of Khasauli's Haat Bazar. Many of the businessmen who are now established in Khasauli began their enterprises in Batauli.

The primary structural factor underlying this reversal is Khasauli's connectivity to the Siddhartha Highway, which links it directly to the Sunauli border crossing with India, to Bhairawa, and to Tansen. This connection has concentrated trade, investment, and population growth on the right bank. By contrast, although Pari Butwal has access to the Mahendra Highway, this advantage has not translated into comparable economic dynamism. The geographical constraints imposed by the surrounding Chure Hills have made large-scale infrastructure development in Batauli considerably more challenging than in the relatively flat terrain of Khasauli.

The pattern of internal migration has further amplified this disparity. As facilities and opportunities expanded in Khasauli, residents of Batauli migrated across the river, and new arrivals from the hilly regions settled preferentially in the more accessible and economically active side of the city. The densification of Khasauli's population has contributed to its commercial vibrancy but has also had social consequences: residents of Khasauli, engaged in the accelerated pace of urban commercial life, reportedly have limited time for the kinds of informal community interactions that remain characteristic of Batauli. The social density of Khasauli contrasts with the relational warmth and communal cohesion documented among Batauli's residents.

There are, however, significant advantages that Pari Butwal retains. Its location in the lap of the Chure Hills means that it remains considerably cooler than Khasauli during summer, when temperatures in Butwal can reach 43 degrees Celsius. The historical and cultural heritage concentrated in Pari Butwal, including Jitgadhi Fort, Manimukunda Sen Park, Purano Bazar, and the ancient houses of Batauli, represents a tourism and educational resource that has not yet been systematically developed. The interfaith community structures documented in this study are themselves assets of social capital that cannot be replicated through urban planning alone.

The researchers submit that the developmental gap between Batauli and Khasauli is neither permanent nor inevitable. It reflects specific historical choices about infrastructure investment, highway connectivity, and urban planning priorities. A deliberate policy commitment to the revitalization of Pari Butwal, encompassing improved transportation infrastructure, flood management along the Tinau River, educational parity, heritage tourism development, and attention to the Sukumbasi settlements, could begin to redress this imbalance. The governing bodies of Butwal Sub-Metropolitan City bear a responsibility to ensure that the origin of their city is not permanently consigned to the periphery of its own story.

Conclusion

This study has examined Pari Butwal through five primary lenses: its military heritage as embodied by Jitgadhi Fort, its royal and ecological heritage as preserved in Manimukunda Sen Park, its commercial history as recorded in Purano Bazar, its architectural heritage as represented by the ancient houses of Batauli, its interfaith social fabric as experienced in the daily life of the community, and its comparative developmental position relative to modern Butwal City.

Across each of these dimensions, a consistent finding emerges: Pari Butwal possesses historical, cultural, and social resources of considerable significance that have not received adequate institutional recognition or developmental investment. The Jitgadhi Fort, where Nepal's military sovereignty was affirmed against one of the world's most powerful imperial forces, remains insufficiently known among the Nepali public. The Manimukunda Sen Park, a site with documented 16th-century origins and active visitor engagement, requires sustained governmental attention. Purano Bazar, the commercial seedbed of modern Butwal, has been effectively emptied of its business community. The ancient houses of Batauli are deteriorating through neglect. And the interfaith brotherhood that characterizes Pari Butwal's social life, while vital and authentic, exists without formal documentation or institutional support.

The fieldwork conducted for this study yielded not only data but perspectives from residents who carry deep personal and generational connections to Pari Butwal. From Mr. Gurung's account of the Jitgadhi victory, to the son of Baje ko Jalebi Pasal who managed the family business for sixty-eight years alone, to Mr. Khan's gesture of wearing a Dhaka topi before an interview with Hindu researchers, these voices constitute a living archive of what Pari Butwal is and what it has

been. Their testimony reinforces the central argument of this study: that Pari Butwal is not merely a historical artifact, but an inhabited, meaningful, and generative place that deserves to be seen as such.

Preserving the heritage of Pari Butwal is not an act of nostalgia. It is an act of civic integrity. Before Butwal was a highway junction, an economic hub, or a sub-metropolitan city, it was a small settlement on a riverbank where Gorkhali soldiers held off an empire, where a king planted a garden, where a market connected the hills to the plains, and where a mosque and a temple stood across from each other without incident. That origin is worth protecting, documenting, and integrating into Nepal's broader national narrative of resilience, diversity, and historical depth.

Interview Respondents

Name	Role	Section
Mr. Hari Bahadur Gurung	Caretaker, Jitgadi Fort	Jitgadi Fort
Mr. Bharat Shakya	Local Historian, Phulbari	Manimukunda Sen Park
Mr. Ishowrlal Joshi	Resident, ancient house	Purano Ghar
Mr. Manish Shrestha	Resident, ancient house	Purano Ghar
Mr. Birendra Mani Thakur	Newari community member	Brotherhood
Mr. Hajir Rahamad Khan Miya	Chairman, Batauli Masjid	Brotherhood
Mr. Rabindra Gopal Kalali	Local resident	Jitgadi Fort

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